KENTUCKY COMMUNITY & TECHNICAL COLLEGE SYSTEM

ESSENTIAL SKILL 8 · FROM YOUR COLLEAGUES

Special Occasion Presentation Team Project

COM 181 · Basic Public Speaking

Teams of three to five plan, write, rehearse, and deliver a ceremonial presentation, such as a retirement tribute or an awards ceremony, as one event-speaking team. The project runs six weeks and is built with backward design. It pairs COM 181 SLOs 2 and 5 with the Milestone behaviors of Essential Skill 8.

Contributed by **Sherri Basil** and adapted with permission for *Designing Collaboration That Works*, the KCTCS faculty guide to Essential Skill 8. Student-facing sections are written to copy into Blackboard. Draft for review, in-house resource.

COURSE
COM 181 (SLOs 2 and 5)

LENGTH
Six weeks

TEAM SIZE
3–5 students

FORMAT
Online or hybrid, in Blackboard Ultra

FINAL PRODUCT
Recorded team presentation, plus an individual reflection

Closest level in the guide: **Level 4 · Sustained**

1 · Quick | 2 · Structured | 3 · Coordinated | **4 · Sustained**

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Using This Project

FOR FACULTY

Introduction to the Project for COM181

This activity aligns to the assignment for creating a Special Occasion/Ceremonial Presentation as a group instead of individually.

Using the current competencies set by the curriculum committee for the course of COM 181. This project will incorporate Competency 2 and Competency 5 while also providing students practice using Essential Skill 8 at the Milestone level of the Kentucky Essential Skills initiated by CPE. Below are the stated Competencies developed by the KCTCS curriculum committee for communication courses.

1. Apply the concepts of the interactive model of communication throughout speech development and delivery.
2. Develop messages appropriate for audience, purpose, and channel in public speaking.
3. Construct logically organized outlines for informative and persuasive speeches.
4. Integrate appropriate supporting materials into speeches.
5. Apply appropriate verbal and nonverbal communication within the delivery of speeches.
6. Employ appropriate and effective language usage within speeches.

This design intentionally integrates Essential Skill 8: Collaborate and Work in Teams with existing communication course outcomes using the backward design model:

1. Identify Desired Results
2. Determine Acceptable Evidence
3. Plan Learning Experiences and Instruction

The design is based on the Kentucky Graduate Profile guidance for Backward Design and Performance-Based Assessment as well as the Essential Skill 8 Milestone descriptors.

Stage 1: Desired Results

This project is a collaborative performance task. Students work in groups to plan for a realistic occasion and audience, apply course concepts, and produce a shared product: a ceremonial presentation delivered as a team.

This activity can be used when you want:

1. Application of theory to “real-world” problems
2. Structured critical thinking and decision-making

Class size & logistics:

- Works well in small groups of 3–5

- Use **Group Assignments** in Blackboard Ultra for a single group submission
- Use **Group Discussion Boards** for early-stage brainstorming, then a shared document or file upload for the final presentation

Good when:

- You have clear prompts and guiding questions
- You can provide a rubric that emphasizes reasoning, use of evidence, and professional communication

Course Student Learning Outcomes (Selected) - a.k.a. Competencies.

This project will directly assess:

SLO 2: Develop messages appropriate for audience, purpose, and channel in public speaking.

SLO 5: Apply appropriate verbal and nonverbal communication within the delivery of speeches.

These outcomes align naturally with a ceremonial or special occasion speech because students must adapt their message to a specific audience and deliver it effectively.

Essential Skill 8: Collaborate and Work in Teams

Students will demonstrate the Milestone Level behaviors:

- Contribute ideas aligned to identified objectives of the team.
- Address conflicts constructively.
- Identify tasks required to reach a goal.
- Learn team members' strengths and distribute responsibilities accordingly.
- Adapt to changing project requirements while maintaining mutual trust and respect.

Learning Goal for Students

Students will collaboratively plan, create, and deliver a Special Occasion/Ceremonial Presentation while demonstrating effective teamwork, communication, and conflict-management skills.

Stage 2: Determine Acceptable Evidence

Performance-Based Assessment

Rather than simply writing a speech, students will complete an authentic performance task.

The Kentucky Graduate Profile recommends using performance-based assessments that require students to actively demonstrate competencies in realistic contexts.

Group Task

Each team will create and deliver a ceremonial presentation for one of the following:

- Retirement celebration
- Community award ceremony

- Scholarship recognition event
- Employee appreciation banquet
- Leadership induction ceremony
- Volunteer recognition event
- Memorial tribute
- Graduation celebration

Students will function as an event-speaking team instead of individual speakers.

Evidence of Communication Learning

SLO 2 Evidence

Students will:

- Identify audience needs
- Determine an appropriate ceremonial purpose
- Adapt message content accordingly
- Develop transitions between speakers

SLO 5 Evidence

Students will:

- Demonstrate vocal delivery
- Demonstrate professional appearance
- Use appropriate eye contact
- Use effective body language
- Deliver a polished presentation

Evidence of Essential Skill 8

Students will demonstrate teamwork through:

Team Planning Document

Students must provide evidence showing:

- Assigned roles
- Responsibilities
- Deadlines
- Meeting notes
- Decision-making process

Blackboard Collaboration Evidence

Students must use Blackboard tools to demonstrate collaboration:

- Group Discussion Board
- Group Assignment Area
- Blackboard Messages
- Shared Group Journal

Reflection Component

After the presentation, students submit an individual reflection:

Reflection Questions

1. How did you contribute to your team's success?
2. What challenges did your team encounter?
3. How did the team manage disagreements or conflict?
4. What would you do differently in future group projects?
5. How did this project help you develop teamwork skills?

Week-by-Week Plan (Stage 3)

FOR FACULTY

Stage 3: Learning Experiences and Instruction

Blackboard Learning Sequence

Week 1 introduces the Essential Skills instruction.

Week 1: Understanding Collaboration

Begin with a mini-lecture on the Essential Skill 8 behaviors students will practice in your course. Include the Essential Skill 8 description, and explain that in the workplace they will often work in teams or workgroups.

Discuss:

- Contributing ideas
- Meeting deadlines
- Respectful communication
- Conflict management
- Shared accountability

Discussion:

This week students should complete the Blackboard discussion board that has been set up in this module. The students will describe their own:

- Best group/team experience
- Worst group/team experience
- What made a difference?

Create a rubric or use the one in the module for the discussion.

Survey:

Students will also answer the questions in the weekly module so that you can add them to a team in which they will best be able to communicate. (See the Collaboration Survey in this packet.)

Week 2: Team Formation and Planning

Blackboard Groups

Students placed into groups of 3-5.

Inside Blackboard Groups students complete:

Team Charter

The team must identify the team goal and the type of presentation.

Individual Roles

Assign a role to each student, or let teams choose.

Examples:

- Lead Organizer
- Speech Writer
- Delivery Coach
- Researcher
- Visual Coordinator
- Editor

Communication Plan (decided by students)

- How often will you communicate?
- Which Blackboard or Microsoft 365 tools will you use?

Conflict Resolution Plan

If disagreements occur:

- Listen first
- Focus on project goals
- Vote if needed

- Contact instructor if necessary

Week 3: Speech Development

Students begin creating content. The group will choose the type of presentation and how each person will contribute. Students research their occasion and audience. Students will function as an event-speaking team instead of individual speakers during the presentation, but will also be graded individually.

Student groups will choose to use one of the following ceremonial topics or others that you may choose.

- Retirement celebration
- Community award ceremony
- Scholarship recognition event
- Employee appreciation banquet
- Leadership induction ceremony
- Volunteer recognition event
- Memorial tribute
- Graduation celebration

You may give them these or other discussion prompts.

Blackboard Group Discussion Prompt:

"Our audience is _____."

"Our purpose is _____."

"Our audience needs to hear _____."

This directly supports:

SLO 2

Develop messages appropriate for audience, purpose, and channel.

Week 4: Peer Feedback Checkpoint

Students will post the presentation outline.

Each team member must provide:

- One strength
- One recommendation
- One question

This part of the project supports Essential Skill 8 through:

- Giving feedback
- Receiving feedback
- Team cohesion

The Kentucky Essential Skills framework highlights constructive conflict management and feedback as key milestone behaviors.

Week 5: Rehearsal and Revision

Each team records a practice version.

Students evaluate:

Delivery Skills Checklist

- Eye contact
- Vocal variety
- Professional language
- Gestures
- Confidence

This supports:

SLO 5

Apply appropriate verbal and nonverbal communication within the delivery of speeches.

Week 6: Final Presentation

Special Occasion/Ceremonial Presentation

Teams submit: (Instructor's Choice)

Video Recording

Requirements:

- All members must participate
- Smooth transitions between speakers (Students may need to set up a time to record together in Microsoft Teams. See 8.2 Microsoft Teams in the Skill 8 guide.)
- Professional delivery
- Audience-appropriate messaging

Project Overview

FOR STUDENTS

Why Are We Completing This Project?

This project is designed to help you develop skills that are important not only in this course, but also in your future career and life beyond college. As part of Kentucky's Graduate Profile, students are expected to develop a set of Essential Skills that employers consistently identify as important for workplace success. One of these skills is Essential Skill 8: Collaborate and Work in Teams, which focuses on working effectively with others, contributing to shared goals, and managing challenges that arise in group settings.

In today's workplace, very few projects are completed alone. Employees are expected to communicate, solve problems, share responsibilities, provide feedback, and work toward common goals with others. This project provides an opportunity to practice those skills in a supportive learning environment while also strengthening your public speaking abilities.

What Will You Do?

Working with a small team, you will plan, develop, and deliver a Special Occasion/Ceremonial Presentation for a specific audience and purpose. As you complete the project, you will:

- Work collaboratively with team members.
- Share ideas and make group decisions.
- Complete assigned responsibilities.
- Practice professional communication.
- Provide and receive constructive feedback.
- Deliver a polished presentation designed for a specific audience and occasion.

How Does This Connect to Our Course?

This project helps you achieve important Communication course outcomes by requiring you to:

- Develop messages that are appropriate for a specific audience and purpose.
- Use effective verbal and nonverbal communication techniques.
- Deliver a professional presentation in collaboration with others.

At the same time, you will intentionally develop Essential Skill 8: Collaborate and Work in Teams by contributing to group discussions, completing responsibilities, supporting teammates, and helping your group achieve its goals

Why Does This Matter?

By the end of this project, you will have practiced skills that employers value across nearly every career field:

- Teamwork
- Communication
- Leadership
- Problem-solving
- Conflict management
- Professional responsibility

More importantly, you will be able to recognize and describe these skills as part of your educational experience and professional development. The goal is not only to create a successful presentation but also to help you become a more effective communicator, collaborator, and future professional.

Student Success Statement

By completing this project, you will demonstrate your ability to communicate effectively with an audience while working collaboratively with others to achieve a common goal—a critical skill for success in college, the workplace, and your future career.

Collaboration Survey (Week 1)

FOR STUDENTS

Directions: This item is designed to help designate teams based on their availability and preferred role in a group.

1. **What is your time zone?**

   ☐ Central ☐ Eastern ☐ Mountain ☐ Pacific

2. **What is your typical availability? (Pick at least one)**

   ☐ Weekday Mornings (9-12) ☐ Afternoons (12 - 4) ☐ Weeknights (after 8 pm)

   ☐ Weekends Only

3. **Preferred Role in a group activity:**

   ☐ Researcher ☐ Writer ☐ Editor ☐ Technology (Graph, PowerPoint, etc.) ☐ Organizer

   ☐ Presenter

Discussion 1: Teamwork and Collaboration

FOR STUDENTS

Learning Objective

Apply principles of effective communication and teamwork by identifying behaviors that contribute to successful group communication and collaboration in professional and academic settings. This activity supports Student Learning Outcome 2: Recognizing how communication changes based on audience and purpose.

Student Activity

- Participate in a Blackboard discussion about positive and negative group experiences.
- Identify examples of effective communication and teamwork.
- Connect personal experiences to Essential Skill 8 collaboration expectations.

In this discussion choose to discuss a positive or negative interaction you have experienced within a group project or while working in a team. Detail how the situation was handled by the other members. Write approximately 500 words. Once you have posted, reply to at least two of your workgroup team members' posts with how you might have handled the situation.

Rubric: Discussion #1 Teamwork and Collaboration

Criterion	Exemplary	Proficient	Developing	Emerging
Length of Post 25% of grade	The post is thorough and well beyond the minimum length, delivering a clear introduction, multiple concrete examples from group experiences, and a well-structured argument that ties into the learning objective.	The post meets length expectations with sufficient detail, includes several relevant examples, and follows a logical flow that connects to teamwork concepts.	The post is brief with only core ideas and a few examples, showing some attempts to connect to teamwork but lacking depth in the discussion.	The post is very short or unfocused, missing clear examples, and fails to link experiences to concepts of collaboration.
Teamwork and Collaboration 30% of grade	Demonstrates outstanding collaboration: cites multiple specific behaviors that contributed to effective group work, discusses roles clearly, and reflects on how these practices influenced outcomes across different settings.	Shows strong teamwork: identifies key collaborative behaviors, describes group dynamics with accuracy, and explains how positive collaboration affected results.	Recognizes some teamwork elements: mentions a few collaboration ideas but lacks depth in how they influenced outcomes or group dynamics.	Struggles to discuss teamwork concepts: offers limited or no examples of effective collaboration or fails to relate to group outcomes.

Criterion	Exemplary	Proficient	Developing	Emerging
Active Listening 25% of grade	Displays active listening through explicit behaviors (paraphrasing, clarifying questions, summarizing) and shows how listening shaped responses and decisions.	Demonstrates solid listening habits with several examples of staying engaged, respectful exchanges, and adjustments based on others' input.	Includes occasional listening behaviors but with limited evidence of impact on the discussion or decisions.	Rarely shows listening efforts or ignores others' contributions, hindering group communication.
Reflection and Application 20% of grade	Provides thoughtful reflection linking personal experiences to essential skill #8, with clear takeaways and explicit plans for applying these insights in future teamwork.	Offers meaningful reflection that connects experiences to collaboration concepts and includes some actionable ideas for improvement.	Gives a basic reflection with limited connection to concepts and few concrete steps for applying lessons.	Minimal or no reflection on experiences; fails to connect discussion to future collaboration or essential skill.

Journal: Evaluating Team Practices Through a Ceremonial Lens

FOR STUDENTS

Your journal should examine how the team's collaboration practices translate into a successful ceremonial presentation. Consider moments when group norms either clarified or constrained progress: how the team distributed tasks, managed timelines, handled feedback, and resolved conflicts. Reflect on how you apply lessons from team dynamics to improve future outcomes, such as refining audience-centered messaging, aligning nonverbal communication with content, or adjusting how you practice public speaking as a unit. Your entry should connect personal growth with collective performance by asking questions like:

What techniques did you implement to ensure coherence across speakers or segments?

How did you adapt the plan when a member's capacity changed?

What would you change next time to foster faster alignment and clearer responsibilities?

Include at least one of the following elements to build authenticity: A Diagram, An Interview, A mock scenario, A Photograph, A Podcast/Speech, A real-life experience, A Reference List, A Video, or A work-related experience.

Frequency: 1. Daily. In your writing, emphasize how the project scaffolds essential skills described in the course outcomes and how collaboration supports professional development and public speaking competence.

Grading note: The original course grades this journal with the Discussion 1 rubric.